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IN THE 1920S, fewer than seven percent of the high school graduates in America went to college, but I was determined to be among them. Jack wasn't offended when I told him I'd set my sights higher than on working at the store, or if he was, he never showed it. I suspect he was proud that one or both of his sons might go to college. But he always told us that, short of a miracle, he wouldn't be able to help us financially. If we wanted a college education, he said we'd have to earn the money to pay for it ourselves.

Moon didn't think it could be done and when he graduated from high school, he got a job at the local cement plant and was soon making almost as much as Jack did. Going to college, he told me, was a waste of time.

But my dream of attending college was firmly planted and I wasn't going to be discouraged easily.

I was drawn to one college in particular. Ever since I could remember, one of Dixon's biggest heroes had been the husky son of one of the ministers who preceded Margaret's father at our church. After starring as a fullback on our high school team, he'd gone to Eureka College and become an even bigger football celebrity there.

My hero worship of Garland Waggoner was boundless and it made me want to follow him to Eureka, a liberal arts college owned by the Disciples of Christ that was located about 110 miles southeast of Dixon.

Although I'd never seen it, Eureka College began to take on an almost mystical allure as my high school years passed. Even repeating its name silently to myself was exciting after a while.